

THE ARCHER

Sagittarius



SIZE RANKING 15

BRIGHTEST STAR
Epsilon (ε) 1.8

GENITIVE Sagittarii

ABBREVIATION Sgr

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
July–AugustFULLY VISIBLE
44°N–90°S

This prominent zodiacal constellation is found between Scorpius and Capricornus in the southern celestial hemisphere. It includes a highly recognizable star pattern called the Teapot, with a pointed lid (λ) and large spout (γ, ε, and δ). The handle of the Teapot is sometimes also called the Milk Dipper.

The Milky Way is particularly broad and rich in Sagittarius, because the center of our galaxy (Sagittarius A) lies in this direction. The exact center of the galaxy is thought to coincide with a radio source known as Sagittarius A*, near where the borders of Sagittarius, Ophiuchus, and Scorpius meet. Sagittarius boasts more Messier objects than any other constellation—it has 15 in all.

Although old star charts depicted this constellation as a centaur, in Greek mythology, Sagittarius was identified as a satyr. He is usually said to be Crotus, son of Pan, who invented archery and went hunting on horseback. He is seen aiming his bow at neighboring Scorpius.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Beta (β) Sagittarii appears to the naked eye as a pair of 4th-magnitude stars. The more northerly (and slightly brighter) of the two stars has a 7th-magnitude companion. All three stars are at different distances, and thus are unrelated.

Probably the finest object for binoculars is M8, the Lagoon Nebula (see p.243), which extends for three times the width of a full moon. It contains the cluster NGC 6530, with stars of 7th magnitude and fainter, as well as the 6th-magnitude blue supergiant 9 Sagittarii.

The Trifid Nebula, M20 (see p.246), is so named because it is trisected by dark lanes of dust. Visually, it is far less impressive than its photographic representation, and little more than the faint double star at its center can be identified through a small instrument.

On the northern border of Sagittarius with Scutum lies another frequently photographed object—the

THE LAGOON NEBULA ♈♊♋

One of the largest nebulae in the sky is M8, which appears in binoculars as an elongated, milky patch of light with embedded stars, including those in the cluster NGC 6530, which make it glow.

Omega Nebula, M17. The loose cluster of stars within it can be detected through binoculars.

M22 is one of the finest globular clusters in the entire sky. Under good conditions, it is visible to the naked eye. Through a small telescope, it is somewhat elliptical in outline, while one with an aperture of 3 in (75 mm) will resolve its brightest stars.

M23 is a large open cluster visible through binoculars near the border with Ophiuchus. M25 is another binocular cluster, while M24 is a bright Milky Way star field the length of four diameters of a full moon.



M22 ♈♊♋

This prominent globular cluster lies near the lid of the Teapot. Through binoculars, it appears as a woolly ball about two-thirds the apparent diameter of a full moon.

